

Freedom of Information Law request — Manhattan Bridge structural records

To the Records Access Officer, New York City Department of Transportation · 55 Water Street, 4th floor, New York, NY 10041 · foiladmin@dot.nyc.gov

Under Article 6 of the New York State Public Officers Law, I request access to the records described below concerning the **Manhattan Bridge**, which opened in 1909 and spans the East River between Canal Street, Manhattan and the Flatbush Avenue Extension, Brooklyn.

The structure is registered under two BINs

The Department registers this bridge as two structures, inspected on different dates and rated separately. **Please treat every item below as applying to both.** A search limited to one BIN would return only part of the structure, and several of the records I am seeking — particularly the deck framing depths — concern the upper level.

BIN	As named in the Condition Report	Carries / crosses	Last inspection	Rating
2240027	MANHATTAN BRIDGE (LL)	East River	14 Nov 2024	6.3 FAIR
2240028	MANHATTAN BRIDGE (UL)	NYCTA tracks — BMT	3 Nov 2022	5.4 FAIR

Source: NYC DOT Bridges and Tunnels Annual Condition Report, 2024 edition.

Form of production

I request **electronic copies** where they exist, delivered by download link or electronic transfer. I do not require certified copies. Where a record exists only on paper, microfilm or aperture card, please tell me its extent and the estimated copying cost before producing it, so that I can narrow the request rather than incur an avoidable fee.

One request about scans. Where drawings are scanned, please provide the **full sheet including the title block and the graphic scale bar**, rather than a cropped detail. A cropped scan cannot be scaled reliably and is of limited use for my purpose.

Records requested

1. Record and as-built drawings of the main bridge

Original construction era, approximately 1901–1912, and any later as-built revisions, including but not limited to:

- a. Tower elevations, plans and sections, including the plan dimensions of the tower shafts, the leg spacing, and the dimensions of the arch openings through the towers.
- b. Details of the tower tops at the cable saddles: the saddle castings and their bearings, and the vertical relationship between the saddle seat and the top of the cable.
- c. Transverse sections through the deck at midspan, at a tower line, and on each approach — dimensioned — showing the out-to-out width, the positions of the four stiffening trusses, the structural depths of the upper roadway, the lower roadway and the transit floor, and the lateral positions of the four transit track centrelines.
- d. The cable and suspender schedule: the main cable profile with sag, and the schedule of suspender lengths along the span. If the original is not available, the equivalent produced for Contract 14 (2010–2013), which replaced all suspenders, would serve equally well.
- e. The longitudinal profile of the upper and lower roadways, with elevations referenced to a stated datum, and a statement of which datum that is.

2. Record and as-built drawings of the anchorages

Both sides: plan dimensions, elevations and sections, including the vaulted thoroughfare passing through each anchorage.

3. Record and as-built drawings of the approach viaducts

Manhattan and Brooklyn, showing bent or pier spacing, the type and structural depth of the longitudinal girders or trusses, and the longitudinal grade down to street level.

4. Foundation and caisson drawings for both towers

Showing the depth of the cutting edge, the height of the caisson, the founding level and the top of the masonry pier, each referenced to a stated datum.

5. Contract and record drawings from the rehabilitation programme begun in 1982

The Department's own Manhattan Bridge page lists these contracts. I am asking for the as-built geometry they document rather than temporary works or means and methods.

Contract	Period	Scope, as the Department describes it
8	1992–1997	Rehabilitation of the South Side Approach and Suspended Spans
8C	1997–2001	Painting of South Side Towers, Cables A and B, interim steel rehabilitation
10	2001–2004	Rehabilitation of North Main Span, North Bikeway, Approach Tunnels
11	2005–2008	Rehabilitation of Lower Roadway, including Manhattan Approach Spans
14	2010–2013	Cable re-wrapping, necklace lighting and suspender replacement
15	2018–2021	Saddles and saddle housings, anchorage housings, truss members, transit floor beams, tower ornamental features

6. The two most recent biennial inspection reports for each BIN

Including attached sketches, load ratings and element-level condition data. The most recent inspections recorded in the 2024 Annual Condition Report are 14 November 2024 for BIN 2240027 and 3 November 2022 for BIN 2240028.

7. Any survey control on the structure

Geodetic coordinates, monument descriptions or control diagrams for the tower centres or anchorage corners, in any stated coordinate system. A single surveyed tower position would be sufficient.

8. Any existing three-dimensional survey of the structure

Laser scan, LiDAR or point cloud data, or a photogrammetric survey, produced for any of the contracts above or for inspection purposes. I would take this in whatever form it exists, including a raw point cloud.

9. Any index, drawing register, aperture-card list or file inventory

Covering the above, together with the portion of the Department's subject matter list maintained under Public Officers Law §87(3)(c) that covers bridge engineering records. If producing the drawings themselves is burdensome, I would value the index first — it would let me identify a much smaller set of specific sheets and resubmit a narrower request.

Context, offered to help locate the records

This is not part of the request. I am building an openly published, source-documented three-dimensional model of the bridge in which every dimension is traceable to a cited source, and anything unsourced is labelled a placeholder and drawn as one. The records above would replace fourteen placeholder dimensions

with documented ones. The project is public at github.com/Ethical-Tech-CoLab/manhattan-bridge-3d and any records provided will be credited to NYC DOT.

Already reviewed, and not requested

So as not to ask for what is already published, I have already obtained and reviewed: the Department's published Manhattan Bridge facts page; the Bridges and Tunnels Annual Condition Report; NYC Open Data holdings; the Historic American Engineering Record survey at the Library of Congress (HAER NY-164, item ny0980, which contains photographs and **no measured drawings**); and the 2010 National Bridge Inventory data sheet for structure 36-2240027. None contains the dimensions sought.

If any part is denied

If any part of this request is denied, please cite the specific statutory exemption for each withheld record and release the remainder, including any reasonably segregable portions.

If security review is required before the release of structural drawings, I am content to receive a **redacted set**, or to narrow the request to the **1901–1912 construction-era drawings alone**, which are more than a century old and describe a structure whose form is visible from the public walkway.

Please acknowledge receipt and provide a date certain for a response.

[Name]

[Postal address]

[Email] · [Phone]

[Date]